

Panelists



G.S. Madhusudan, CEO,
Incore Semiconductors



Dr Madhura Purnaprajna,
Professor, PES University



Ramanan Ramanathan, Senior
Vice President, TCS, First
Mission Director For Atal
Innovation Mission



Ravi Subramanian,
Partner, ekLakshaya
Innovation Labs

projects are done in colleges as part of the curriculum,” says Subramanian.

There arises a doubt whether full-blown products can be created in spite of opportunities everywhere. A lot of companies organise competitions to sponsor good ideas and convert them into useful products. The product or the prototype can be shoddy, but the process of engineering is what experts love to focus on.

Sadly, we do not have encouraging collaboration between the institutions and industries to share industry’s problems to research and find solutions. Ramanan Ramanathan, Senior Vice President, TCS and First Mission Director for Atal Innovation Mission, appreciates the efforts of Niti Aayog, some universities, and government initiatives that enable research and collective development. He suggests setting up of incubators by industries to provide opportunities and increase capabilities. Rather than just placement, industries should also encourage research activities.

Ramanathan points out the success of Atal Innovation Mission, which has seen overwhelming response from industry and universities. It has over 10,000 mentors to support budding engineering students. He says, “Setting up an incubation centre is a method of having industry and technology partners to attain a mentoring network. I think

the government should also do its role in encouraging such interactions. However, the universities and industries have to practically play the role they want to participate in. There has to be a very proactive approach and an awareness of the industry’s role in boosting and making India self-reliant and enabling the export of electronics.”

Boosting entrepreneurship

The industry-academia collaboration seems to be a two-way street. There are universities and colleges that have established incubation centres. Whereas in entrepreneurship, the journey does not happen in a day, but starts from the level of entrepreneurial thinking. It involves reading, listening, and calculating to develop the culture of entrepreneurship and innovation. There is a proactive marketing requirement by academia to the industry.

For instance, if there is a problem faced by an innovator in an MSME that does not have the bandwidth to help in solving it, it could approach an academia’s industry cell. They should pay small stipends to such academia. When done actively, this opens up a way to expose students to industry’s actual needs, which would help in building the future entrepreneurs.

India has more than 400 incubators and over 55,000 startups. The country has pushed its position from

the 81st to the 48th place in just five years in the global innovation index.

Ramanathan considers infrastructure as the second pillar of self-reliance followed by technology demand. “By reducing the dependency on imports through greater emphasis on local manufacturing, design, electronic development, we can boost our exports. All we need to do is to empower the young students by creating an ecosystem of innovation, entrepreneurship, and the ability to do advanced research,” he says.

Madhusudan thinks the curriculum is too heavy with theory and that there is a serious need to have a significantly stronger practical focus. With not many lab exercises that are spread throughout the course, we need to revisit the practical curriculum, he opines.

Unfortunately, India has a cultural problem, where going into business is considered capitalism and has negative connotations in most parts of the country. It becomes easier to discourage entrepreneurship in such a scenario. **EFY**

This article has been compiled by Abhinaya Kuzhanthaivel, an Assistant Editor at EFY, from a panel discussion held at Asia Innovation Summit 2021. The panelists in the discussion were Dr Madhura Purnaprajna, Professor, PES University; Ramanan Ramanathan, Senior Vice President, TCS, and First Mission Director For Atal Innovation Mission; Ravi Subramanian, Partner, ekLakshaya Innovation Labs; and G.S. Madhusudan, CEO, Incore Semiconductors